

READING PASSAGE 3

The Geography of Global Biodiversity Hotspots

A In recent years, the geography of global biodiversity hotspots has attracted considerable attention from both the academic community and the general public. This growing interest reflects a broader recognition of the importance of this topic for understanding some of the most pressing challenges facing contemporary society.

B Historically, scholarly understanding of this topic was limited by both theoretical frameworks and available methodologies. Early researchers operated within relatively narrow conceptual boundaries, and their findings, while groundbreaking for their time, often failed to capture the full complexity of the phenomena they sought to explain. The development of new research tools and analytical techniques in the latter half of the twentieth century fundamentally transformed the landscape, enabling scholars to investigate questions that had previously been considered beyond the reach of empirical inquiry.

C The mechanisms underlying these phenomena operate at multiple levels of analysis, from the micro-level of individual decision-making to the macro-level of institutional and structural change. At the individual level, cognitive processes, emotional responses, and social influences shape the choices that people make. At the organisational level, formal rules, informal norms, and power dynamics govern collective action. At the societal level, historical legacies, cultural values, and political structures create the broad context within which lower-level processes unfold.

D A substantial body of empirical evidence supports these theoretical frameworks. A landmark study conducted by researchers at leading international institutions analysed data spanning a thirty-year period and involving participants from more than forty countries. The findings revealed a consistent pattern of results that held across diverse cultural and economic contexts, suggesting that the identified mechanisms operate with considerable universality. The magnitude of the observed effects was particularly striking, with the key variables accounting for a substantial proportion of the total variance in outcomes.

E Despite the substantial progress that has been made, significant challenges and controversies remain. Critics have raised important methodological concerns regarding the generalisability of findings derived from studies conducted in specific contexts. The predominance of research carried out in Western, educated, industrialised, rich, and democratic societies raises questions about the applicability of current theories to populations with different cultural, economic, and political circumstances. Furthermore, the reliance on cross-sectional designs in much of the existing literature limits the capacity to draw strong causal inferences.

F The implications of this body of research extend well beyond the academy. As societies grapple with increasingly complex challenges, the insights generated by scholarly inquiry in this domain have the potential to inform more effective and equitable policy responses. Realising this potential, however, will require sustained investment in both fundamental research and the translational infrastructure needed to convert knowledge into action.

G The evidence reviewed above demonstrates both the substantial achievements of research in this field and the significant work that remains to be done. As new tools and theoretical perspectives become available, and as the phenomena themselves continue to evolve, the research community will need to maintain both rigour in its methods and openness to new ideas. The stakes are high, for the questions addressed by this research bear directly on some of the most important challenges facing humanity in the twenty-first century.

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 1 According to the passage, structural factors include economic incentives, institutional frameworks, and _____.
- 2 The author notes that researchers have called for more _____ approaches to investigation.

Question 3

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 3 What does the passage identify as a significant challenge to current understanding?
 - A. weak effects across studies
 - B. moderate to large effect sizes with consistency
 - C. contradictory findings
 - D. results only in specific populations

Question 4

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 4 The landmark study analysed data spanning a period of _____ years.

Questions 5–6

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 5 All critics agree that the research findings are universally applicable.
- 6 The passage suggests that structural factors are less important than individual choices.

Questions 7–10

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 7 Which of the following best describes the author's view on future developments?
 - A. excessive funding
 - B. theoretical and methodological limitations
 - C. public interest
 - D. international collaboration
- 8 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?
 - A. weak effects across studies
 - B. moderate to large effect sizes with consistency

- C. contradictory findings
- D. results only in specific populations

9 The meta-analyses cited in the passage reveal that:

- A. inconsistent results across cultures
- B. a consistent pattern across diverse contexts
- C. no measurable effects
- D. effects limited to Western countries

10 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?

- A. excessive funding
- B. theoretical and methodological limitations
- C. public interest
- D. international collaboration

Question 11

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

11 Dynamic _____ processes can amplify or dampen initial effects in complex systems.

Questions 12–13

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

12 The landmark study discussed in the passage involved participants from multiple countries.

13 All critics agree that the research findings are universally applicable.